KDE Netbook shell
KDE has offered a netbook-optimised shell since KDE SC 4.4; it's optimised for smaller displays and is quite touch friendly

KDE SC 4.7
The latest 4.7 version of KDE SC is just around the corner, and is to be released on the 27th of July

KDE Plasma Active

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Computing form factors have changed a lot in the past few years. Netbooks became quite favourable for a while, before falling into disfavour with tablets gaining a foothold and seeming to be the form factor of the coming generation. Until something better replaces them, of course.

Still, there's a clear inclination towards smaller multi-touch capable screens, and the same is reflected in the new user interfaces that we're seeing on next generation operating systems. Windows 8, for example, has a new tile interface, that can support new forms of applications that work better on touch screens. Gnome 3 too has an interface optimised for smaller screens with touch support, and the new Unity interface for Ubuntu 11.04 developed by Canonical also seems to bear the new form factors in mind.

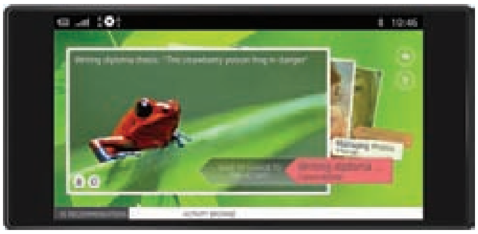
More important however, are applications. On a tablet form factor, people expect to do more than they can on a smartphone, and while there certainly are people who purchase powerful smartphones with no intention of installing third-party applications, tablet users will generally want more out of their devices than what the device can deliver by default.

Plasma Active is the KDE community's entry into user interfaces for new form factor devices. The KDE community was quick to embrace the netbook form factor with a netbook shell simply called Plasma Netbook. They were able to release something quickly because Plasma – a new framework released with KDE 4.0 – is incredibly flexible and separates the data from the user interface.

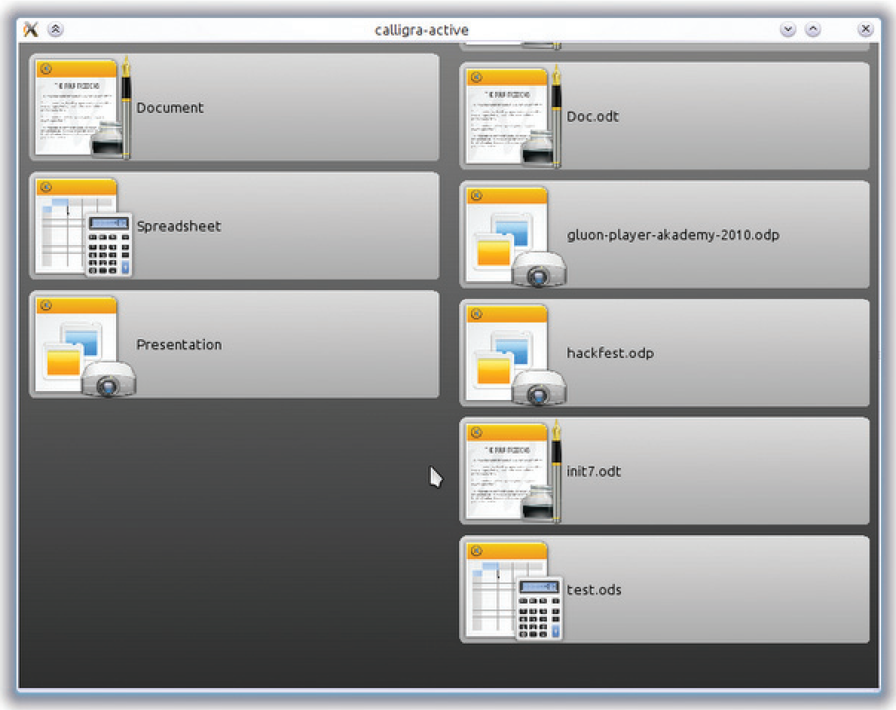
Plasma Active is a new effort to take plasma to non-PC environments such as tablets, smartphones etc. Its mission statement is to "create a desirable user experience encompassing a spectrum of devices".

User experience has been put front and centre and the goal is not simply to port KDE software and workspaces to run on tablets, but also to develop a completely new UI that better suits the form factor for which it's being developed. Not just the core KDE Software Compilation (SC) experience, but also the KDE apps are being redesigned to fit the new form factor. The initial target is tablet computers.

To achieve this vision of KDE running on a "spectrum of devices", the KDE community is working on five separate but converging tracks:



Browsing activities on Contour



Calligra Active (Tablet version of Calligra, the KDE Office Suite)

Plasma Quick

This is an initiative to upgrade the underlying plasma infrastructure to make it better suitable for devices. This will entail performance improvements, stability improvements, etc. and these benefits will also come to those using KDE SC on desktops.

Since plasma is based on Qt, it will also take advantage of some of the new features that were added to Qt in its recent releases. These features include Qt Quick and QML, which make it very easy and simple to create rich UIs.

Contour

Contour is a new data-centric user interface for the tablet form factor with an aim to "create a context-sensitive user interface that adapts to the user's current context, activities and behavioral patterns" (instead of opening an application that deals with the data you want, sorting and searching). The data could be your contacts or social network stream. Contour, on the other hand, will combine data with the current context (geolocation, time, etc) and usage patterns and provide different ways of dealing with that data.